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Judgment seat, tribunal

3.19 Judgment seat, tribunal

References:

Greek βῆμα (bēma) MAT 27:19, JHN 19:13, ACT 12:21, ACT 18:12, ACT 18:16, ACT 18:17, ACT 25:6, ACT 25:10, ACT 25:17, ROM 14:10, 2CO 5:10

Greek δίφρος (difros) SIR 38:33

Latin sedes iudicii 2ES 7:33

Description:

The tribunal was a raised platform mounted by steps and usually furnished with a seat. It was used by officials in addressing an assembly, often on judicial matters. One tribunal excavated in Corinth (and possibly the same one mentioned in ACT 18:12) was a small platform supported by stone blocks and with a narrow railing around the top.

Translation:

The association of the Greek word bēma with judicial procedures means that there is almost always an important component of judicial function associated with this term. The focus upon judgment is particularly important in those passages that refer to the judgment seat of God (ROM 14:10) and of Christ (2CO 5:10). However, in those passages where a historical judicial event is in focus (all of the references in the Gospels and Acts), it will not usually be necessary to specify the place of judgment in translation. The following models illustrate this: “While Pilate was judging the case” (MAT 27:19 in CEV), “took him into court” (ACT 18:12 in GNT), and “he opened the legal proceedings” (ACT 25:6 in GECL).

If translators wish to preserve the idea of a specific place of judgment, it is possible to use a phrase such as “place where a judge decides,” “place where decisions are made,” or “judge’s seat.”